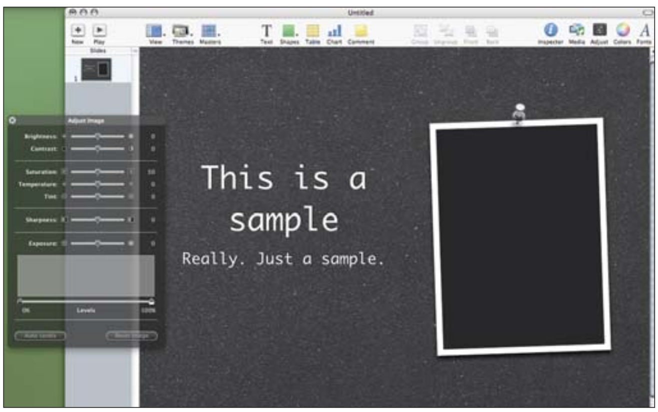
SUSE comes with Beagle Desktop Search pre-installed, and there's a search box in the start menu as well. While Beagle is a competent tool—it indexes your files, e-mail, address book, and even sticky notes—it doesn't give you results as you type. You need to install Beagle separately in Ubuntu—the pre-installed search tool is about as fast as XP's default search.

And now to the heart of the matter.

The Applications

You have an OS, and it naturally follows that applications must exist for it. With Vista, the question doesn't arise—so we'll talk about OS X and Linux.

That there aren't applications for OS X and Linux is a myth, but the likelihood that you won't find a Mac or Linux version of your essential tools is quite high. There's often an alternative, but then you need to assess the quality of that alternative before making a switch.



Keynote is one of those "killer apps" on the Mac. It's a brilliant alternative to PowerPoint, and is much easier to use

In the office suite department, you can opt for either Microsoft Office 2004 or OpenOffice.org for the Mac (the latter for Linux, too). If you're used to the Office 2007 interface on Windows, however, it's like going back in time, so we'd recommend waiting till Office 2008 releases for the Mac later this year. Read about more software for OS X in this month's *Fast Track*. Applications for the Mac—especially the paid ones—feel tightly integrated with OS X and are quite easy to figure out.

You can also run Windows applications on OS X and Linux using CrossOver—we recommend this option over Wine because you pay for the support, and if you're working with applications that handle critical data, you want a minion who's paid to solve problems you encounter. On the Mac, you can also use BootCamp or Parallels desktop to run XP or Vista, so you can run Windows-only applications when you need to, and switch back to OS X for the rest of your work.

Weighing these alternative methods to run Windows applications against the alternatives depends on how many Windows-only applications you can't live without. You'd feel like quite the jackass if you bought a MacBook Pro for over a lakh only to find yourself using Windows XP on BootCamp more often than OS X. Ditto for Linux—you'll rest easier running Windows applications on Windows.

Getting Them, Throwing Them

On Windows, applications leave traces behind, and there's the task of removing those traces—like cleaning your Registry. What do OS X and Linux offer?

To install an OS X application, you just download a .dmg (disk image) file, mount it by double-clicking, and drag the application to the Applications folder to your hard disk—that's it! Some applications come with installers, but the former is what you'll encounter more often. When you're done with an application, just drag it to the Trash and it's gone! All this sounds too good to be true, and it is. The application as it appears to us—a .app file—is actually a folder, much like the application folder in your Program Files directory—complete with executables, settings and so on. There's no system registry, so when you delete the .app file, the application is gone. However, a lot of applications store information—particularly user-specific settings—in the Library/Application Support folder (the OS X equivalent of the Documents and Settings folder in Windows), and these files remain even when you've deleted an application—you'll have to manually remove these.

With SUSE and Ubuntu, you can install software through online repositories. This works better than installing through downloaded packages because of the evil of dependencies. Application A won't run if you haven't installed library B, and library B is incomplete without libraries C and D. Both distributions have their own official repositories, but they aren't configured with the SUSE install, because the software available isn't part of your support contract. You have to add the OpenSUSE repositories manually, and this isn't pleasant—it took us many tries to even get a connection to the server, and the operation would fail even then. Ubuntu is much better—you can start installing applications seconds after your first login, and the selection is vast.

In both cases, dependencies are automatically installed—the flip side is that you need a fairly fast Internet connection and a large download limit.

The Security Angle

Security has been a priority in Vista's development, we've been told time and again, but the number of exploits mushrooming for the new OS says a lot more. True, it takes security a bit more seriously—users aren't logged in as Admin-

Vista even makes you authorise its own Control Panel applets before they make major changes. UAC isn't foolproof, and it can get on your nerves but it's a good thing to have regardless